

CAN IDEAS CHANGE THE WORLD?

“It’s about leadership and ability to choose wisely”

HEMANT CHAWLA



RAVI S SAHANI



HEMANT CHAWLA



(FROM LEFT)
DUBNER, ALLAN
AND WANG

“Simple and cheap ideas work wonders”

STEPHEN DUBNER CO-AUTHOR,
FREAKONOMICS

Can ideas change the world? Of course, they can. That's what ideas are meant to do. But those that change the world are often not big and complex, but simple ideas—cheap and extraordinarily valuable.

One example: At the Vienna General Hospital in Austria there was an onset of plague in the 1840s. The death toll from the Puerperal Fever, where healthy women died right after child birth, zoomed to one in six by 1847. That year young Dr Ignaz Semmelweis began probing the

issue. As he gathered data, the dots joined up: The deaths had something to do with the way doctors working on a cadaver in the autopsy ward went for deliveries without washing their hands. Mandatory hand rinsing in antiseptic, chlorinated water brought down the death toll from 16 per cent to less than one in a week. At a time when science hadn't quite caught up with the idea of microbes, the brainwave solved a pressing problem and saved lives.

In 1991, Mount Pinatubo, a dormant volcano in the Philippines, suddenly began to shake and rumble, spewing out 20 million tonnes of sulphur dioxide and ash 20 miles into the sky. An exciting moment, as scientists found out that sulphur in the stratosphere formed a shield, cooling the earth. A Pinatubo every two years can stop global warming, they realised, not just what it is now, but what is expected to